Incident report: webhook backlog after the 2026-03-12 outage

Document: INC-306

Date: 2026-03-13

Services: notifications

Summary

During the March 12, 2026 outage, the notifications service experienced a significant backlog of merchant webhooks. Payment events queued up faster than the notification workers could process them. The Merchant Experience team scaled the notification worker fleet in response, clearing the backlog within approximately 90 minutes.

Impact

A total of 26,900 webhooks were delayed during and after the outage. Merchants experienced delayed notifications about payment events, which affected their ability to reconcile transactions and update order statuses in real time. The backlog persisted until worker capacity was increased.

Timeline

- 15:05 UTC: Notification workers scaled up via CHG-1045
- 16:30 UTC: Webhook backlog cleared

For details on the broader outage context, see INC-301.

Root Cause

The notifications service depends on the payments-api and ledger services to emit payment events. When these services experienced issues during the March 12 outage, payment events continued to be generated but the notification workers could not keep pace with the queue depth. The worker fleet size was insufficient to handle the event volume during recovery.

Resolution

Hannah Kim and the Merchant Experience team executed CHG-1045 to scale the notification workers from 8 to 24 instances at 15:05 UTC. This increase in capacity allowed the service to process the accumulated webhooks. The backlog was fully cleared by 16:30 UTC.

Follow-up Actions

- Review RB-07 to ensure webhook backlog procedures are current and effective
- Evaluate baseline notification worker capacity to prevent similar backlogs during future incidents
- Consider implementing automated scaling policies for the notifications service based on queue depth thresholds